

Pratham Education Foundation



Founded

1995, Mumbai

Founders

Dr. Madhav Chavan and Farida Lambay

Sector

Education

"Every child in school and learning well"

Recognition

- Kravis Leadership Prize (2010)
- Skoll Award (2011)
- WISE Prize, Madhav Chavan (2012)
- BBVA Frontiers of Knowledge Award
- Lui Che Woo Prize (2018)
- Yidan Prize, Rukmini Banerji (2021)

About Pratham

Pratham, meaning "first" in Sanskrit, is one of India's largest education non-profits. It was founded in Mumbai, growing out of an initiative with UNICEF and the city's authorities, and began with balwadis (preschools) and remedial classes for children in the city's slums.

It expanded to other cities, moved into rural India in 2002, and became a national organisation with the first ASER survey in

2005. Today it works on learning and earning, for children, youth and women, directly in communities and through government partnerships.

Its model relies on staff working alongside volunteers from local communities, with high-quality, low-cost and replicable interventions. Dr. Rukmini Banerji led Pratham as CEO from 2015 to 2026, succeeding Dr. Chavan.



Milestones



Core Programmes

Teaching at the Right Level

Groups children by learning level rather than grade to build basic reading and maths. A 2012 Bihar pilot led to statewide partnerships in six states, and TaRL is now used across India and in several African countries.

ASER and the ASER Centre

A citizen-led household survey of children's learning, first run in 2005 and reaching every rural district. The ASER Centre (2008) generates evidence for action, and the tool has been adopted in Pakistan, Kenya and beyond.

Early Childhood Education

Pratham's original work, starting with balwadis in Mumbai's slums, preparing young children for school.

Second Chance

Since 2011, helps girls and women who dropped out complete secondary school. The Pratham–Jameel programme (2023) supports 10,000 girls toward grade 10.

Vulnerable Children

The Pratham Council for Vulnerable Children works with children in child labour and other marginalised situations, including freeing 17,000+ children from Mumbai's zari industry in 2005.

Digital and Global

Digital literacy and numeracy tools since 2015, remote learning during COVID-19, and global partnerships through TaRL Africa and Pratham International.

Impact

~7.5M

Children reached in India (2025–26)

24

States and UTs, ~20,000 communities (2025–26)

~33M

Children reached through Read India (2007–09)

10M

Children assessed by 375,000 volunteers (2015–16)

17,000+

Children freed from child labour (2005)

30+

Countries reached worldwide (2025)